

EASTERN HIMALAYAS

Earth's highest mountains support a variety of rare species

The peaks and steep-sided valleys of the world's highest mountain range are home to varied but vulnerable plants and animals. The lower and middle elevations of the Eastern Himalayas are covered with various types of forest. Depending on latitude and altitude, they might be subtropical or temperate, evergreen, or deciduous. Oaks and rhododendrons dominate the forests, which support a diverse array of wildlife. Even above the treeline, seemingly inhospitable rocky slopes are home to such elusive creatures as the snow leopard and blue sheep.

Vital water regulators

The mountains and their forests are also important for the region's water supply. They catch and gradually release rainwater to tributaries of some of Asia's most iconic rivers, including the Ganges and the Brahmaputra. The plants and animals of the high Himalayas are likely

to experience great challenges due to climate change, as the melting of glaciers accelerates and they are forced to adapt to warmer temperatures, if they can.

There are 163 globally threatened species in the Eastern Himalayas, and a quarter of their original habitat remains intact. The challenge for conservationists is to protect sufficiently large areas and corridors between them to sustain animals that range over large areas. The main threat to the forests and their wildlife comes from poaching, collection of wood for fires and charcoal, and habitat loss or damage resulting from agricultural practices.



WILD YAK

ADAPTED TO THE COLD
The wild yak conserves body heat in the cold mountain climate—generating it uses valuable energy. It stores fat beneath its skin, and its thick, dark fleece has a layer of soft insulating down and another of coarse outer hair.

Boasts 9 of the world's 10 highest peaks



HIMALAYAN BLUE SHEEP

NATURAL CAMOUFLAGE
The Himalayan blue sheep's gray-blue coat provides superb camouflage against its rocky environment. This agile animal is able to climb up steep cliffs when trying to escape predators such as the snow leopard.

BLOOMING PARTNERSHIP

The higher elevations of the Himalayas feature a diversity of rhododendron species. More than 50 flourish in the Indian state of Sikkim and 60 in Bhutan. Rhododendron forests support insects and birds that pollinate the flowers when feeding on nectar.



RHODODENDRON

Home to 10,000 plant species and nearly 1,000

